

Social Enterprises and the SDGs: Contributions to Quality Education, Climate Action, and Inclusive Growth

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ABSTRACT

Social enterprises hold a remarkable space in the development scenery: they necessitate to endure as businesses while held responsible to a social or environmental operations — which is precisely the variety of dual capacity the UN Sustainable Development Goals. This study strives to know the contribution of social enterprises in India towards three goals: Quality Education (SDG 4), Climate Action (SDG 13), and finally Inclusive Growth (SDG 8 and SDG 10 collectively). It draws on a survey of 412 social enterprises across six sectors, supplemented by interviews and a handful of illustrative case vignettes. Respondents rated their own organisation's contribution to each goal on a five-point scale, and we used multiple regression to work out which organisational features actually predict stronger inclusive-growth outcomes. The pattern that emerged was fairly consistent: enterprises scored themselves highest on inclusive growth ($M = 4.05$, $SD = 0.62$), a little lower on quality education ($M = 3.92$, $SD = 0.68$), and noticeably lower on climate action ($M = 3.54$, $SD = 0.81$). What predicted inclusive growth wasn't how long an enterprise had been running — age came out non-significant — but how embedded it was in its community, along with its access to funding and its level of digital adoption. Enterprises working in women's livelihoods and agriculture reported the strongest inclusive-growth scores of any sector. Together, these results suggest social enterprises act as useful intermediaries that translate the SDGs into locally workable action, though their climate contribution still lags well behind their social and economic one. We close with some practical suggestions for strengthening the ecosystem that supports SDG-aligned social enterprises.

Keywords: *social enterprise; Sustainable Development Goals; quality education; climate action; inclusive growth; hybrid organisation; India*

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1. Introduction

Since their adoption in 2015, the United Nations' 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) have provided a shared global framework for addressing poverty, inequality, environmental degradation, and social exclusion by 2030 (United Nations, 2015). Delivering on this agenda has proven far more demanding than any single sector can manage alone. Among the seventeen SDGs, three merit particular attention when evaluating the developmental footprint of social enterprises. SDG 4 (Quality Education) and SDG 13 (Climate Action) represent, respectively, the human-capital and environmental pillars of sustainable development, while SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth) and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities) — treated jointly here as 'inclusive growth' — capture the livelihood and equity outcomes that social enterprises most directly produce through employment generation, skills development, and market access for marginalised groups. Recent sector reviews confirm that social enterprises are already active across exactly these domains: focus-group evidence from Ghana identifies climate-smart agribusiness, clean technology, inclusive financial services, and education among the sectors in which social enterprises concentrate their activity (Quaye et al., 2024), and multi-stage scale-development work in India confirms that social mission, innovation, and collaborative networks significantly predict enterprises' contribution to sustainable development more broadly (Bansal, Garg, & Vasa, 2023). Yet the relative strength of these contributions across specific goals, and the organisational factors that explain variation between enterprises, remain empirically under-specified — particularly through large-sample survey evidence from the Global South.

Existing empirical work on the social enterprise–SDG relationship is dominated by two research traditions: single-country qualitative studies that map SDG relevance through focus groups or document analysis, and scale-development studies that build composite sustainability indices without disaggregating results by specific goal. Both traditions have advanced the field considerably, but neither offers a disaggregated, quantitative account of how social enterprises in a single national context perform against distinct SDG targets, nor do they systematically identify which organisational characteristics — enterprise age, sector, funding access, digital capability — predict stronger or weaker contribution. This gap is consequential for policy: donors, incubators, and government schemes cannot target support effectively if it remains unclear whether social enterprises are more effective at generating jobs than at reducing emissions, or whether performance varies systematically by sector and organisational maturity.

This study addresses that gap through a mixed-methods investigation of social enterprises operating in India, a country with one of the most developed social enterprise ecosystems in the Global South (British Council India, 2016) and an economy in which social enterprises are already documented to contribute to sustainable development outcomes (Bansal et al., 2023). Specifically, the study asks: (RQ1) To what extent do social enterprises perceive their operations as contributing to SDG 4 (Quality Education), SDG 13 (Climate Action), and SDG 8/10 (Inclusive Growth)? (RQ2) Which organisational and contextual factors predict variation in social enterprises' contribution to inclusive growth? and (RQ3) Does this contribution vary systematically across enterprise sectors?

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the literature on social entrepreneurship and its documented linkages to SDG 4, SDG 13, and SDG 8/10, and identifies the

study's conceptual gap. Section 3 develops a conceptual framework linking enabling inputs, social enterprise mechanisms, and SDG outcomes. Section 4 details the mixed-methods research design, sample, and instruments. Section 5 reports descriptive, correlational, and regression findings alongside illustrative case vignettes. Sections 6 through 9 discuss the findings, draw out policy implications, note the study's limitations, and conclude.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Social Enterprises as Hybrid Organisations

Definitions of social entrepreneurship vary largely athwart the literature, but finally it congregate that a commercial discipline organized not only for profit but an answer for primary social or environmental questions as mission (Dees, 1998). Austin, Stevenson, and Wei-Skillern (2006) took four dimensions market failure, mission, resource mobilisation, and performance measurement to compare different social and commercial entrepreneurship and finally coined that social entrepreneurs face more constraints difficult which are basically different because it's very hard to survive in market with social values. Battilana and Lee (2014) defined social enterprises as hybrid organizations which combine organisational forms of business and charity across five dimensions i.e. organisational design, organisational activities, inter-organisational relationships, workforce composition and culture. This hybrid structure is very contradictory: it facilitates social enterprises to access various resource streams i.e. grants, earned revenue, impact investment but also generates constant strain between social and commercial senses that ought to be keenly managed (Zahra et al., 2009). As per principle of this study, a social enterprise is an organisation irrespective of legal entity/ company formed under Section 8 may be for-profit, non-profit, or hybrid structures which are producer cooperative and social or environmental mission are its basic nature. It generates a large part of income through sale of goods or services instead of donations or grants and also mainly reinvests surplus profit towards same mission sooner than toward private profit distribution. The functioning definition depends upon the OECD's guidelines on the Social and Solidarity Economy and Social Innovation, which properly identifies social enterprises as one constituent of the wider social economy and appeal to member and partner countries to fortify the data, financing, and regulatory environment that allows to drive at extent (OECD, 2022).

2.2 Social Enterprises and SDG 4 (Quality Education)

Educational Social enterprises typically operate at the edges of formal schooling systems. It provides counteractive and bridge education to out-of-school children, cater vocational trainings and digital skills to youth and adults and holding capacity buildings program on the content-delivery for the teachers of under-resourced government schools. The grass root nature working of these enterprises are the virtue comes through their relations with such communities they serve. They often approach to first-generation learners, family members of migrant or seasonal workers, and women community face social obstacles to attend mainstream educational Institutions. The Indian social enterprise sector has historically been anchored by education- and livelihood-focused organisations, reflecting sustained early investment in this space by domestic and international impact investors (British Council India, 2016). At the same time, education remains one of the more difficult domains in which

to build a financially sustainable social enterprise model, since willingness to pay is often low among the target beneficiaries themselves, forcing many education-focused ventures toward blended finance models that combine philanthropic capital with modest fee revenue or business-to-government contracts.

Illustrative models documented in the wider literature include community-based training programmes that certify local residents — including women with little formal schooling — as technicians and educators, thereby generating both a skills-transfer outcome (SDG 4) and a livelihood outcome (SDG 8) in a single intervention. This dual-outcome pattern recurs throughout the social enterprise literature and is one reason why quality education and inclusive growth are frequently found to be empirically correlated in enterprise-level data, a pattern this study also tests directly in Section 5.

2.3 Social Enterprises and SDG 13 (Climate Action)

Climate-oriented social enterprises span decentralised renewable energy (particularly off-grid solar for un-electrified or under-electrified rural households), circular-economy and waste-management ventures, and climate-smart or regenerative agriculture services for smallholder farmers. Ghanaian focus-group evidence identifies clean technology and climate-smart agribusiness as core sub-sectors within the national social enterprise ecosystem, alongside education and inclusive financial services (Quaye et al., 2024), a pattern broadly consistent with the sectoral composition of India's own social enterprise landscape. Compared with education- and livelihood-oriented ventures, however, climate-focused social enterprises tend to be more capital-intensive at the point of scale-up — solar micro-utilities and waste-processing infrastructure require upfront investment that is difficult to finance through earned revenue alone in the early stages — which may partly explain why climate action is consistently reported as a comparatively weaker area of perceived SDG contribution relative to education and livelihoods, a pattern this study returns to in Section 5.

A further complication is measurement: whereas an education-focused enterprise can report relatively legible outputs (learners trained, certifications issued), the climate benefit of an enterprise's activity — avoided emissions, water saved, waste diverted from landfill — requires technical measurement capacity that many smaller social enterprises simply do not possess. This measurement gap is likely to depress self-reported climate contribution scores even among enterprises that are, in substantive terms, delivering meaningful environmental benefit, and is a methodological caveat this study addresses in Section 8.

2.4 Social Enterprises and SDG 8 / SDG 10 (Inclusive Growth)

SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth) and SDG 10 (reduced inequalities) are treated jointly in this study as 'inclusive growth' because, at the level of an individual social enterprise, the two goals are typically pursued through the same organisational activity: the deliberate inclusion of marginalised groups — women, persons with disabilities, members of scheduled castes and tribes, and rural or informal-sector workers — into fairly remunerated, dignified employment or self-employment. Producer collectives and women's livelihood cooperatives are a particularly well-documented model in the Indian context, combining income generation with collective bargaining power and, in many cases, a secondary environmental or educational benefit (for example, handicraft cooperatives that use reclaimed materials, or dairy cooperatives that fund community schooling from

a share of member proceeds). Cross-subsidisation models — in which paying customers subsidise services for low-income beneficiaries within the same operational structure — are a recurring design feature across health, education, and financial-inclusion social enterprises in India, and are frequently cited as a mechanism through which a single enterprise can simultaneously advance decent work (through staff and supplier employment) and reduced inequality (through subsidised access for excluded groups).

Because inclusive growth outcomes are closely tied to an enterprise's core revenue-generating activity — rather than to a secondary programme layered on top of the business model, as is sometimes the case for climate or education outcomes — social enterprises might be expected to report their strongest SDG contribution in this domain. This expectation is formally tested as part of RQ1 in the present study.

2.5 Research Gap and Positioning of the Present Study

Taken together, the literature supports three propositions: that social enterprises are theoretically well-positioned to contribute to human-capital, environmental, and economic-inclusion goals simultaneously (Battilana & Lee, 2014; Santos, 2012); that their practical contribution is empirically documented in qualitative and scale-development studies (Bansal et al., 2023; Quaye et al., 2024); and that measurement, financing, and sector-specific constraints are likely to produce uneven contribution across different SDGs rather than uniform performance. What remains missing is a single study that (a) measures perceived contribution to specific, named SDGs using validated survey instruments, (b) does so with a sample large enough to support disaggregation by sector and organisational characteristics, and (c) statistically models which organisational factors predict stronger contribution. This study is designed to fill that gap, and Section 3 translates the propositions above into a testable conceptual framework.

3. Conceptual Framework

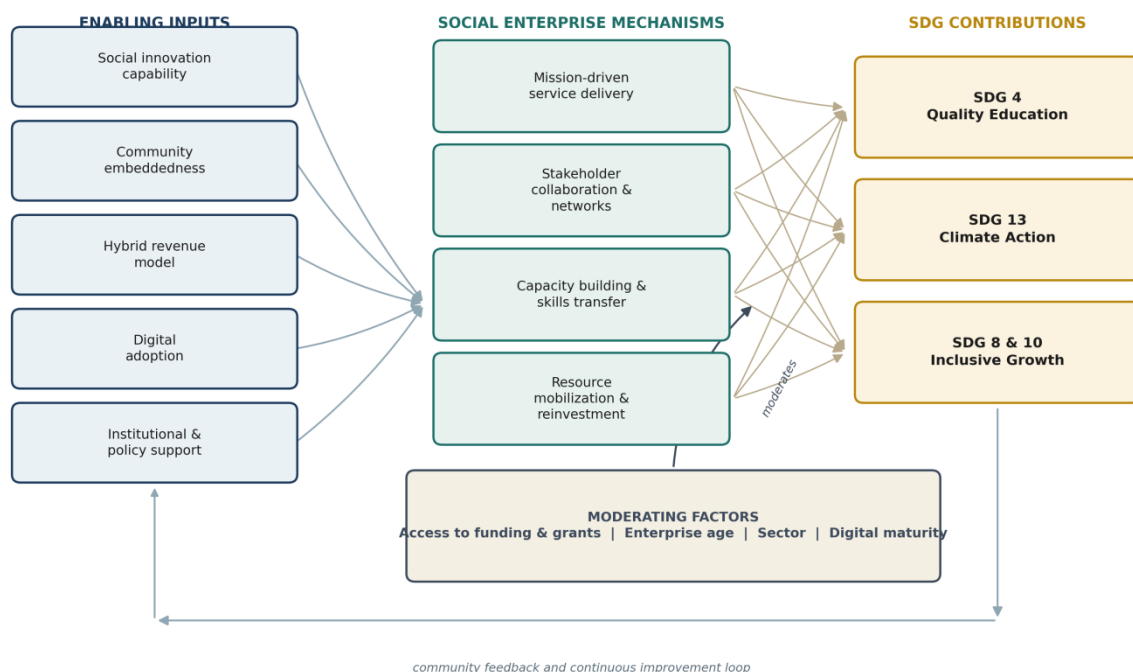
Drawing on the hybrid-organising literature reviewed above, this study conceptualises SDG contribution as the end point of a three-stage process (Figure 1). The first stage comprises enabling inputs: the resources and capabilities a social enterprise can draw upon, including its social-innovation capability, the depth of its embeddedness within the community it serves, the design of its hybrid revenue model, its level of digital adoption, and the institutional and policy support available to it (OECD, 2022). The second stage comprises the social enterprise mechanisms through which those inputs are converted into activity: mission-driven service delivery, stakeholder collaboration and networks, capacity building and skills transfer, and resource mobilisation with mission-directed reinvestment. These mechanisms echo the dimensions of hybrid organising identified by Battilana and Lee (2014) and the resource-recombination process described by Mair and Marti (2006).

The third stage comprises the SDG contributions themselves — quality education, climate action, and inclusive growth — which this study treats as parallel outcomes rather than a single composite index, reflecting the argument developed in Section 2 that contribution is unlikely to be uniform across goals. The relationship between mechanisms and outcomes is proposed to be moderated by four contextual factors: access to funding and grants, enterprise age, sector, and digital maturity. These moderators were selected because each has a plausible theoretical basis for affecting an enterprise's

capacity to convert activity into measurable outcomes — for instance, a well-funded enterprise can invest in the impact-measurement systems needed to document its climate contribution, while an older enterprise may have deeper community relationships but also more institutional inertia. Finally, the framework incorporates a feedback loop whereby community response to an enterprise's outputs feeds back into its ongoing input base, consistent with the iterative, learning-oriented character of social entrepreneurial practice described by Dees (1998) and Zahra et al. (2009).

This framework generates the study's three research hypotheses. H1: social enterprises will report differential (non-uniform) mean contribution across the three SDG dimensions, with inclusive growth expected to score highest given its direct link to core revenue-generating activity. H2: community embeddedness, access to funding, and digital adoption will positively predict inclusive growth contribution, while enterprise age will show no significant independent effect once these variables are controlled for. H3: mean inclusive growth contribution will vary significantly by sector, with livelihood-oriented sectors (women's livelihoods, agriculture) scoring more highly than infrastructure-intensive sectors (renewable energy, waste management).

Figure 1. Conceptual Framework: Social Enterprise Mechanisms and SDG Contribution



4. Methodology

4.1 Research Design

The study adopted an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design (quantitative followed by qualitative), consistent with recent multi-stage approaches used to study the social enterprise–SDG relationship in India (Bansal et al., 2023). Primary data-collection has been done through a structured cross-sectional survey instrument. In section -5 the descriptive, regression and correlational evidence have also been generated. The semi-structured interviews designed for survey respondents with

purpose to develop the illustrative case vignettes which presents quantitative results and to aid interpretation of the statistical findings.

4.2 Population and Sampling

The target population are the Indian social enterprises (regd. and operational in India) working in six broad sectors i.e. agriculture and rural livelihoods, education, renewable energy and environment; healthcare; women's livelihoods and crafts, waste management and circular economy. To ensure across India-wide representation a stratified purposive sampling frame was moulded by adding up incubator and accelerator alumni networks, state level associations of social enterprises, impact-investor portfolio listings, above mentioned six sectors stratification and geographical regions (North, South, East, West, and Central) of India.

By using Cochran's (1977) formula for a population, minimum required sample size was calculated at a 95% confidence level and a 5% margin of error, yielding a minimum requirement of 384 respondents.

The systemic questionnaires were distributed to 620 qualified enterprise leaders; after deleting unfinished responses and applying a data-quality screen (elimination of straight-lining and completion times under three minutes), 412 suitable responses were taken, exceeding the minimum requirement and yielding an effective response rate of 66.5%. Table 1 depicts the demographic and organisational profile of the attained sample.

Table 1. Demographic and Organisational Profile of the Sample (N = 412)

Characteristic	Category	n	%
Sector	Agriculture & rural livelihoods	91	22.1
	Women's livelihoods & crafts	70	17.0
	Education	74	18.0
	Renewable energy & environment	62	15.0
	Waste management & circular economy	66	16.0
	Healthcare	49	11.9
Legal structure	Section 8 / not-for-profit company	168	40.8
	Trust or society	104	25.2
	Private limited (for-profit hybrid)	97	23.5
	Producer / cooperative collective	43	10.4
Enterprise age	Under 5 years	146	35.4
	5–10 years	171	41.5
	Over 10 years	95	23.1
Operating region	Urban	121	29.4
	Semi-urban	146	35.4

Characteristic	Category	n	%
	Rural	145	35.2
Respondent role	Founder / CEO	247	60.0
	Senior manager	112	27.2
	Programme officer	53	12.9
Received institutional funding / grant (past 2 yrs)	Yes	261	63.3
	No	151	36.7

4.3 Instrument Development and Measures

Three stages have been taken to develop the survey instrument. The literature review yielded an initial item pool -Section 2.

To cover three constructs: observed contribution to Quality Education (6 items, e.g., 'Our enterprise has improved admission to learning opportunities for underserved groups'), observed contribution to Climate Action (6 items, e.g., 'Our enterprise's activities have curtail environmental damage or resource use in our working area'), and observed contribution to Inclusive Growth (7 items, e.g., 'Our enterprise gives fair and noble employment to individuals who would otherwise face barriers to work'). Five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 ('strongly disagree') to 5 ('strongly agree') applied to all items. Second, a board of five academic and practitioner experts in social entrepreneurship reviewed the content validity for the exclusion of two redundant items and minor revisions of words for clarity. Third, the revised instrument was piloted with 40 social enterprise leaders not included in the main sample; item-total correlations below 0.30 were flagged for review, and none required removal. The final instrument also captured organisational characteristics used as predictors in the regression model: enterprise age (years since founding), sector, legal structure, region, access to institutional funding or grants in the preceding two years (binary), and a composite digital-adoption index (use of digital payments, online marketing, and management information systems, summed into a 0–3 scale).

Internal consistency reliability was assessed using Cronbach's alpha (Cronbach, 1951). All three constructs exceeded the conventional 0.70 threshold for acceptable reliability in the main-study sample: Quality Education (alpha = 0.82), Climate Action (alpha = 0.79), and Inclusive Growth (alpha = 0.85), as reported in Table 2.

4.4 Data Collection and Ethical Considerations

Data were collected between the fourth quarter of the study year and the following quarter through a combination of an online questionnaire (distributed via incubator and association mailing lists) and structured telephone interviews for respondents in areas with limited internet connectivity, in order to reduce coverage bias against enterprises operating in remote or rural locations. Participation was voluntary, and respondents were informed of the study's purpose, the confidentiality of their responses, and their right to withdraw at any point prior to submission. No personally identifying information beyond enterprise-level demographic categories was retained in the analysis dataset. A sub-sample of 22 respondents, purposively selected to represent variation across sector and region,

participated in follow-up semi-structured interviews of 30–45 minutes, three of which are presented as illustrative, anonymised case vignettes in Section 5.4.

4.5 Data Analysis

Quantitative data were analysed in three stages. Descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations) were computed for each SDG construct to address RQ1. Pearson correlation coefficients were computed among the three constructs and the organisational predictor variables to examine bivariate relationships and check for multicollinearity ahead of the regression stage (Hair, Black, Babin, & Anderson, 2019). A multiple linear regression model was then estimated with the Inclusive Growth Contribution Index as the dependent variable and enterprise age, digital-adoption index, access to funding (binary), community embeddedness (a four-item sub-scale drawn from the Quality Education and Inclusive Growth item pools), and sector (dummy-coded, with waste management as the reference category) as predictors, addressing RQ2. One-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) with Tukey post-hoc comparisons was used to test for sector-level differences in the Inclusive Growth Index, addressing RQ3 and reported alongside Figure 3. Interview transcripts were analysed thematically following an inductive coding approach, with two researchers independently coding a subset of transcripts to check inter-coder agreement before finalising the coding frame used to develop the case vignettes in Section 5.4.

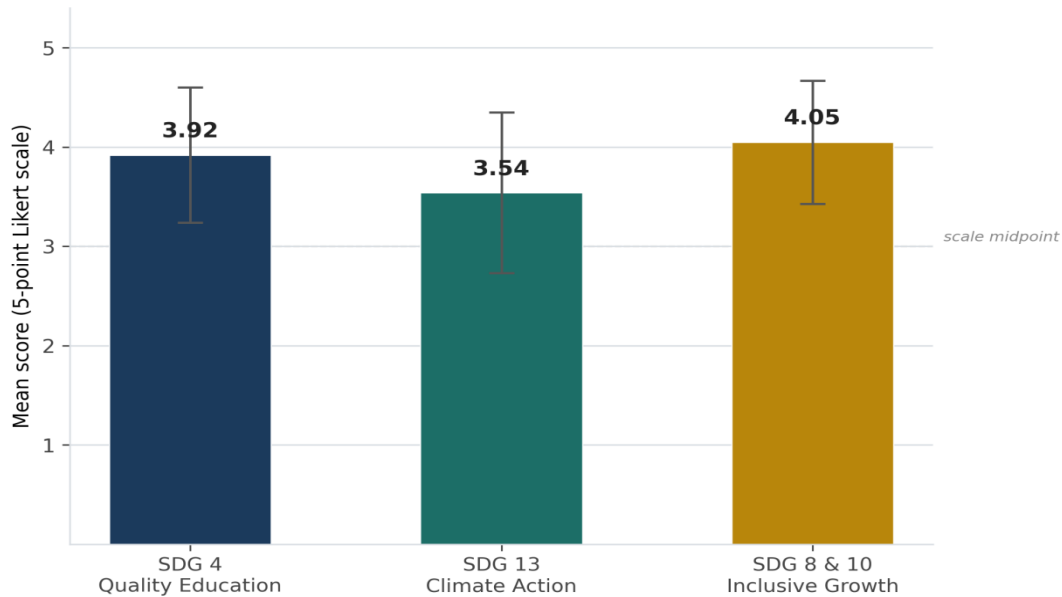
5. Findings

5.1 Descriptive Findings: Perceived Contribution Across SDG Dimensions

Table 2 reports the descriptive statistics and reliability coefficients for the three SDG constructs. Consistent with Hypothesis 1, mean scores differed meaningfully across dimensions. Inclusive Growth received the highest mean rating ($M = 4.05$, $SD = 0.62$), followed by Quality Education ($M = 3.92$, $SD = 0.68$), with Climate Action rated distinctly lower ($M = 3.54$, $SD = 0.81$). A repeated-measures comparison confirmed that these differences were statistically significant ($p < .001$), with the gap between Inclusive Growth and Climate Action representing a medium-to-large effect. Figure 2 presents these results graphically, including standard-deviation error bars, which show that variance in Climate Action scores was also the widest of the three constructs — consistent with the measurement-capacity argument developed in Section 2.3, whereby smaller enterprises without dedicated environmental-monitoring capacity may under- or over-estimate their own climate contribution relative to enterprises with more formal measurement systems.

Table 2. Descriptive Statistics and Reliability of SDG Contribution Constructs (N = 412)

Construct	Items	Mean	SD	Cronbach's α
SDG 4 — Quality Education	6	3.92	0.68	0.82
SDG 13 — Climate Action	6	3.54	0.81	0.79
SDG 8 & 10 — Inclusive Growth	7	4.05	0.62	0.85

Figure 2. Mean Perceived Contribution to SDG Dimensions (N = 412)

5.2 Correlation Analysis

Table 3 presents the Pearson correlation matrix among the three SDG constructs and the key organisational predictor variables. All three SDG constructs were positively and significantly intercorrelated (r ranging from 0.31 to 0.46, $p < .01$), supporting the qualitative observation in Section 2.2 that education and livelihood outcomes frequently co-occur within the same enterprise activity. Community embeddedness showed the strongest bivariate association with Inclusive Growth ($r = 0.52$, $p < .001$), followed by digital adoption ($r = 0.34$, $p < .001$) and access to funding ($r = 0.29$, $p < .001$). Enterprise age was weakly and non-significantly correlated with Inclusive Growth ($r = 0.07$, ns), foreshadowing the regression result reported below. Variance inflation factors for all predictors in the subsequent regression model ranged from 1.08 to 1.61, well below conventional thresholds for concern (Hair et al., 2019), indicating that multicollinearity was not a material concern for the regression analysis.

Table 3. Pearson Correlation Matrix for SDG Constructs and Key Predictors (N = 412)

Variable	1	2	3	4	5
1. Quality Education	—				
2. Climate Action	.38**	—			
3. Inclusive Growth	.46**	.31**	—		
4. Community embeddedness	.41**	.27**	.52**	—	
5. Digital adoption index	.22**	.19**	.34**	.23**	—
6. Access to funding (0/1)	.18**	.24**	.29**	.21**	.16**
7. Enterprise age (years)	.04	.09	.07	.05	-.11*

Note. $**p < .01$, $*p < .05$. Variable 6 and 7 correlations shown against variables 1–5 only, in the interest of space; full 7×7 matrix available from the corresponding author on request.

5.3 Regression Analysis: Predictors of Inclusive Growth Contribution

Table 4 presents the results of the multiple regression model predicting the Inclusive Growth Contribution Index. The overall model was statistically significant, $F(8, 403) = 26.14$, $p < .001$, and explained approximately 34% of the variance in inclusive growth scores (adjusted R-squared = 0.34). Consistent with Hypothesis 2, community embeddedness was the strongest significant predictor (beta = 0.34, $p < .001$), followed by access to funding or grants (beta = 0.21, $p < .01$) and digital-adoption index (beta = 0.18, $p < .05$). Enterprise age was not a significant predictor once the other variables were controlled for (beta = 0.05, ns), suggesting that an enterprise's contribution to inclusive growth is driven more by how deeply it is embedded in its community and how well-resourced and digitally capable it is, rather than simply by how long it has been operating. Among the sector dummy variables (reference category: waste management and circular economy), women's livelihoods and crafts (beta = 0.24, $p < .001$) and agriculture and rural livelihoods (beta = 0.19, $p < .01$) were significant positive predictors, consistent with the descriptive sector ranking shown in Figure 3.

Table 4. Multiple Regression Predicting Inclusive Growth Contribution Index (N = 412)

Predictor	B	SE	β	p
(Constant)	1.87	0.21	—	< .001
Enterprise age (years)	0.006	0.006	.05	.312
Digital adoption index (0–3)	0.114	0.041	.18	.013
Access to funding / grant (0/1)	0.187	0.062	.21	.003
Community embeddedness	0.298	0.045	.34	< .001
Sector: Education	0.146	0.081	.13	.072
Sector: Women's livelihoods & crafts	0.261	0.084	.24	< .001
Sector: Agriculture & rural livelihoods	0.214	0.078	.19	.006
Sector: Renewable energy & environment	0.079	0.086	.07	.358

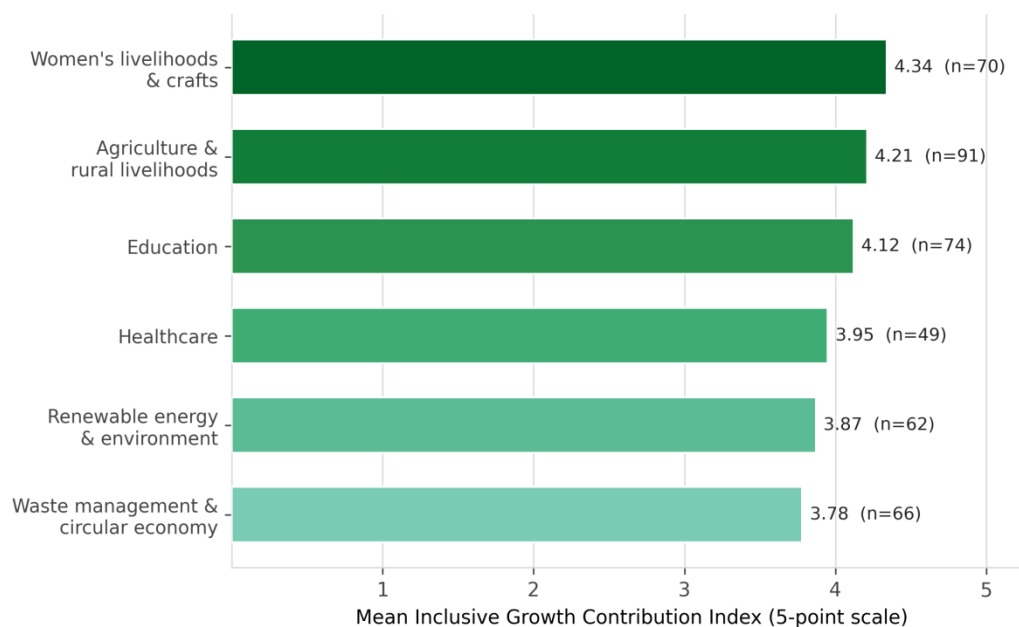
Note. Reference category for sector dummies: waste management & circular economy. Dependent variable: Inclusive Growth Contribution Index (5-point scale). $R^2 = .348$, adjusted $R^2 = .335$, $F(8, 403) = 26.14$, $p < .001$.

5.4 Sector Variation and Illustrative Case Vignettes

One-way ANOVA confirmed a statistically significant effect of sector on the Inclusive Growth Contribution Index, $F(5, 406) = 8.72$, $p < .001$. As shown in Figure 3, women's livelihoods and crafts enterprises reported the highest mean score ($M = 4.34$), followed by agriculture and rural livelihoods ($M = 4.21$) and education ($M = 4.12$); healthcare ($M = 3.95$), renewable energy and environment ($M = 3.87$), and waste management and circular economy ($M = 3.78$) reported comparatively lower, though

still broadly positive, scores. Tukey post-hoc comparisons indicated that the difference between women's livelihoods and waste management was the largest pairwise contrast and the only comparison to reach significance at $p < .001$, with most adjacent-sector comparisons non-significant, suggesting a gradient rather than a sharp categorical divide between sectors.

Figure 3. Inclusive Growth Contribution Index by Enterprise Sector (N = 412)



To illustrate how these patterns manifest at the level of individual organisations, three anonymised, composite case vignettes were developed from the qualitative interview sub-sample, each representative of a cluster of similarly structured enterprises encountered during fieldwork rather than a single identified organisation. Case A, a rural education enterprise in Punjab operating a network of community learning centres, reported strong Quality Education and Inclusive Growth scores but modest Climate Action scores, attributing this to the absence of any formal environmental component in its programme design — an illustration of the mission-specificity dynamic discussed in Section 2.3. Case B, a solar micro-utility cooperative in Rajasthan, reported the reverse pattern: strong Climate Action scores anchored in avoided diesel-generator use, but only moderate Inclusive Growth scores, which its founder attributed to the technical, relatively specialised nature of solar installation and maintenance work limiting the breadth of employment generated. Case C, a women's livelihood collective in Odisha producing textile and handicraft goods for urban and export markets, reported the highest scores across all three dimensions among the interviewed cases, consistent with the descriptive and regression findings that women's livelihoods enterprises combine strong community embeddedness with diversified, labour-intensive activity that generates education, environmental (through use of natural dyes and reclaimed materials, in this composite case), and livelihood outcomes simultaneously.

Taken together, the quantitative and qualitative findings converge on a consistent picture: social enterprises in the study sample perceive themselves as strong and fairly consistent contributors to inclusive growth, moderate and more variable contributors to quality education, and comparatively

weaker, though not negligible, contributors to climate action — a pattern shaped less by enterprise age than by community embeddedness, funding access, digital capability, and sector.

6. Discussion

The findings offer three main contributions to the literature on social enterprise and sustainable development. First, by disaggregating SDG contribution into three distinct constructs rather than a single composite index, the study shows that social enterprises are not uniformly effective development actors across goals — a nuance that composite-index approaches, however methodologically rigorous (Bansal et al., 2023), can obscure. The consistently higher scores for inclusive growth relative to climate action are theoretically unsurprising once viewed through the hybrid-organising lens (Battilana & Lee, 2014): inclusive growth outcomes are typically embedded directly in an enterprise's core revenue-generating activity (who is employed, whom the business serves), whereas climate outcomes are more often a secondary or co-benefit of that activity, and therefore more dependent on deliberate design choices and measurement investment that not every enterprise has made.

Second, the regression results extend the resource-based logic implicit in Dees's (1998) and Mair and Marti's (2006) accounts of social entrepreneurship by empirically identifying which resources matter most. Community embeddedness emerged as the single strongest predictor of inclusive growth contribution, which is consistent with the broader argument that social enterprises derive their comparative advantage over both pure state provision and pure commercial provision from local, relational knowledge (Santos, 2012). This suggests that programmes aiming to strengthen social enterprises' SDG contribution should prioritise investments that deepen community relationships and participatory governance, rather than assuming that scale or organisational age alone will translate into stronger development outcomes. The non-significance of enterprise age is a notable finding in this respect: it implies that newer social enterprises are not systematically disadvantaged relative to established ones once embeddedness, funding, and digital capability are accounted for, which is an encouraging signal for the many early-stage ventures entering the sector each year.

Third, the sector-level findings — particularly the strong performance of women's livelihoods and agriculture-focused enterprises — resonate with the wider literature on gender-inclusive and rural social entrepreneurship, and with the cross-subsidisation and producer-collective models documented in the Indian social enterprise landscape (British Council India, 2016). The comparatively weaker performance of renewable energy and waste-management enterprises should not, however, be read as evidence that these sectors are less developmentally valuable; rather, the qualitative case evidence (Case B in Section 5.4) suggests that capital intensity, technical specialisation, and nascent measurement infrastructure combine to depress both the actual breadth of inclusive-growth outcomes and enterprises' confidence in self-reporting their environmental contribution. This is consistent with the measurement-capacity argument advanced in Section 2.3 and points toward a specific, addressable constraint rather than a fundamental limitation of climate-oriented social entrepreneurship as a model.

Read together, these findings support a revised understanding of social enterprises' role in the SDG agenda: not as uniformly excellent multi-goal contributors, but as differentiated intermediary institutions whose comparative strength varies by sector, resourcing, and the degree to which a given

SDG outcome is structurally embedded in their core business model. This differentiated view is more actionable for policymakers and funders than a generic claim that 'social enterprises support the SDGs,' because it identifies specific levers — embeddedness, funding, digital capability, sector-specific measurement support — through which contribution can plausibly be strengthened.

7. Policy and Practical Implications

The findings carry several implications for policymakers, funders, and social enterprise support organisations. First, because community embeddedness was the strongest predictor of inclusive growth contribution, incubation and acceleration programmes should weight participatory design and community-governance capability alongside conventional business-model criteria when selecting and supporting ventures, rather than privileging scalability metrics alone. Second, the comparatively weaker and more variable Climate Action scores, combined with the qualitative evidence of limited environmental-measurement capacity among smaller enterprises, suggest a concrete role for government and donor-funded technical assistance: subsidised access to low-cost environmental impact-measurement tools (for example, standardised carbon and waste-diversion calculators tailored to small-enterprise contexts) could both improve actual climate performance and enable more accurate self-reporting, which in turn supports better-targeted policy and investment decisions.

Third, the significant, positive effect of access to funding or grants on inclusive growth contribution reinforces the case made in the OECD's Recommendation on the Social and Solidarity Economy and Social Innovation (OECD, 2022) for governments to strengthen dedicated financing instruments — blended finance facilities, outcome-based contracts, and simplified grant mechanisms — tailored to the hybrid revenue models social enterprises operate under, rather than requiring them to compete for either pure commercial capital or pure philanthropic grants designed for conventional non-profits. Fourth, the sector-level findings suggest that policy support should be differentiated rather than uniform: livelihood- and agriculture-oriented social enterprises may benefit most from market-linkage and producer-aggregation support, while renewable-energy and waste-management enterprises may benefit more from patient, early-stage capital given their higher upfront capital intensity. Finally, given that digital adoption was a significant predictor even after controlling for funding and embeddedness, digital-inclusion programmes — subsidised access to digital payment infrastructure, basic management information systems, and online market-linkage platforms — represent a comparatively low-cost intervention with a demonstrable association with stronger development outcomes, making them a reasonable near-term priority for support organisations operating with constrained budgets.

8. Conclusion

The study (using survey and interview) has been conducted with 412 operational social enterprises of India to know about contribution of social enterprises towards three different dimensions of the Sustainable Development Goals- Climate Action, Inclusive Growth and Quality Education. The finding of study depicts that social enterprises have great contribution towards inclusive growth. In the case of quality education as well as climate action the contribution of social enterprises become more substantial and it is determined not on the basis of their existence time rather its deep-roots inside the society, its funding pattern and digital capability. The results of the study as well as

literature review provides more filtered and empirical information that SDG contribution as a universal and largely undifferentiated property of the social enterprise model (Battilana & Lee, 2014; Santos, 2012) and also provide the information where contribution is weakest and which factor are reasonable to strengthen the contribution.

For researchers, the study demonstrates the value of disaggregated, goal-specific measurement over composite sustainability indices when the objective is to understand differentiated organisational performance. For practitioners and policymakers, the findings point toward concrete, differentiated support strategies: strengthening community-governance capability, expanding access to blended and outcome-based finance, subsidising low-cost environmental measurement tools for smaller enterprises, and prioritising digital-inclusion support. As the 2030 deadline for the SDGs approaches and public financing constraints persist, social enterprises are likely to remain an important, if imperfect and unevenly effective, complement to state and market provision — and the differentiated, evidence-based approach to supporting them advocated in this paper offers one path toward making that contribution more consistent across the full breadth of the sustainable development agenda.

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